# CS/DS Undergraduate Thesis and IT Capstone Project Oral Examination Guidelines

Grace Tacadao, MSIT
CS Department

Raul Vincent Lumapas, PhD
IT Department

3 November 2026

## 1 Mode of Meeting

The primary mode of meeting is In-Person. However, a Google Meet link is provided in the Google Calendar invitation for panelists who are unable to arrive at the meeting room on time. Such panelists are expected to join the meeting remotely initially and eventually attend in person to ask the proponents questions and participate in the panel's caucus.

## 2 Pre-Defense Requirements

There are three requirements that the proponents must fulfill before proceeding with the thesis defense:

1. The thesis defense fee must be settled before the scheduled thesis defense.
2. The adviser must complete and sign the *Thesis Defense Endorsement Form* to formally endorse the group for the thesis defense.
3. The proponents must complete the *Attestation of Primary Authorship and AI Disclosure Statement* and submit the duly accomplished document before the thesis defense.

## 3 Attire

The proponents are expected to wear business-casual attire during the defense.

## 4 Punctuality and Attendance

The proponents are expected to arrive early for their defense schedule. They should be in the meeting room 15 minutes before the start of the defense. Tardiness of more than 15 minutes means forfeiture of the defense slot and, consequently, a failure in the subject.

All the members of the group must be present during the defense. If a member of the group cannot attend or is delayed due to an emergency, a formal excuse letter must be submitted to and approved by the thesis moderator, who will then arrange a new defense date.

## 5 Use of Mobile Device

The use of mobile phones and tablets during the oral examination is strictly prohibited, including for accessing notes. Proponents are expected to bring printed copies of their notes and shall not use their mobile phones or other electronic devices for this purpose.

Likewise, panelists are requested to refrain from using their mobile devices or engaging in other tasks or activities unrelated to the oral examination, out of respect for the presenters.

More importantly, recording the proceedings in any form is strictly prohibited. The proponents are encouraged to bring a notebook and pen to take note of the panelists' comments. Furthermore, the adviser shall document the revisions required from the group.

# 6 Thesis Defense Proper

## 6.1 The Presentation

The proponents' presentation should not exceed 20 minutes. The slide deck should contain no more than 20 slides, with approximately 1 minute allocated to each slide. The slide deck should be composed of the following:

1. Title (slide)
2. Introduction (1 slide)
3. Objectives of the Study (1 slide)
4. Conceptual Framework (1 slide)
5. Methodology:
   (a) Descriptive Analysis or Case Study (whichever applies) (1 slide)
   (b) Model Design (CS) or System Architecture (IT) (1 slide)
   (c) Experimental Setup (1 slide)
   (d) Evaluation Metrics (1 slide)
6. Results and Discussion (at most 10 slides)
7. Conclusions (1 slide)
8. Recommendations (1 slide)

## 6.2 Interrogation

The examiners will ask questions regarding the proponents' data, conceptual framework, results, limitations, and future work. The interrogation should not exceed 25 minutes.

## 6.3 Caucus

The panel will discuss and evaluate the merits of the proponents' performance and manuscript. They will then decide whether to give the proponents a PASS, a PASS WITH MINOR REVISIONS, a PASS WITH MAJOR REVISIONS, or a FAIL.

## 6.4 Verdict

After the caucus, the panel shall give its verdict on the thesis project based on the following criteria:

1. PASS
   The thesis satisfies all requirements. No corrections are necessary.
2. PASS WITH MINOR REVISIONS
   The verdict shall be given to proponents whose manuscript requires only minor corrections such as grammatical, spelling and formatting corrections. Formatting corrections include use of boldface, uppercase, and line spacing.

3. PASS WITH MAJOR REVISIONS
   The verdict shall be given to the proponents whose thesis project requires substantial revisions involving one or more of the following:

   - One of the thesis objectives has not been adequately addressed.
   - A required subsection is missing.
   - Failure to follow the prescribed manuscript structure or substantial non-compliance with the required formatting guidelines.
   - The content of a subsection is substantially misplaced or inadequately organised.
   - The evaluation needs to be redone or additional experiments are required.

4. FAIL
   The verdict shall be given to the proponents whose thesis project exhibits one or more of the following:

   - At least two thesis objectives have not been adequately addressed.
   - Required chapters and/or sections are missing.
   - The proposed approach has not been evaluated against an appropriate baseline, as required for CS projects. (CS)
   - There is evidence of fabrication and falsification of results.
   - The proponents are unable to adequately explain or defend the fundamental concepts, methodology, and results of their own work.

The required revisions shall be jointly reviewed and verified by the adviser and the moderator on a mutually agreed-upon date following the thesis defense. The moderator shall be responsible for checking the manuscript's compliance with the prescribed formatting guidelines.

The decision of the panel regarding the thesis project's verdict shall be **FINAL AND BINDING**. No appeal or request for reconsideration shall be entertained, and NO RE-DEFENSE shall be scheduled following the panel's decision.

## 6.5 Score sheets

The panelists, including the adviser, shall evaluate both the presentation and the manuscript using the prescribed rubrics. If the panel decides to give the group a FAIL verdict, the score sheets shall no longer be collected.